

Cohesive self-service experience

Creating a vision for a unified experience.

ROLE

Lead Designer

TEAM

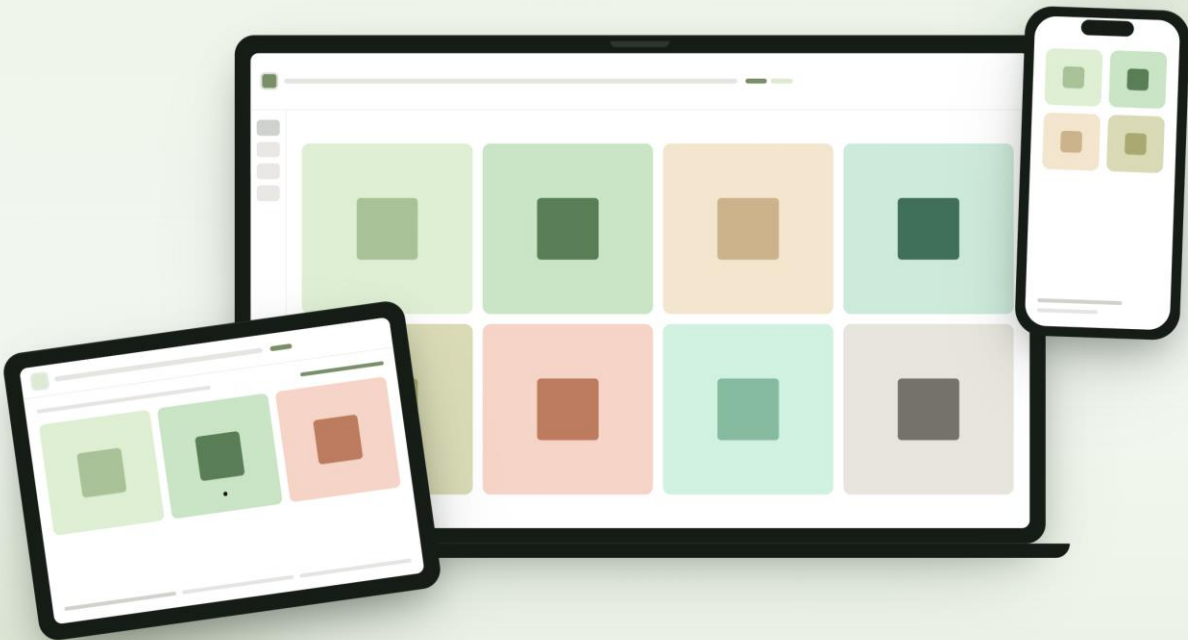
Design Manager · Researcher · 3 PMs · Engineers

TIMELINE

2026 · ongoing

STATUS

Beta · Being implemented

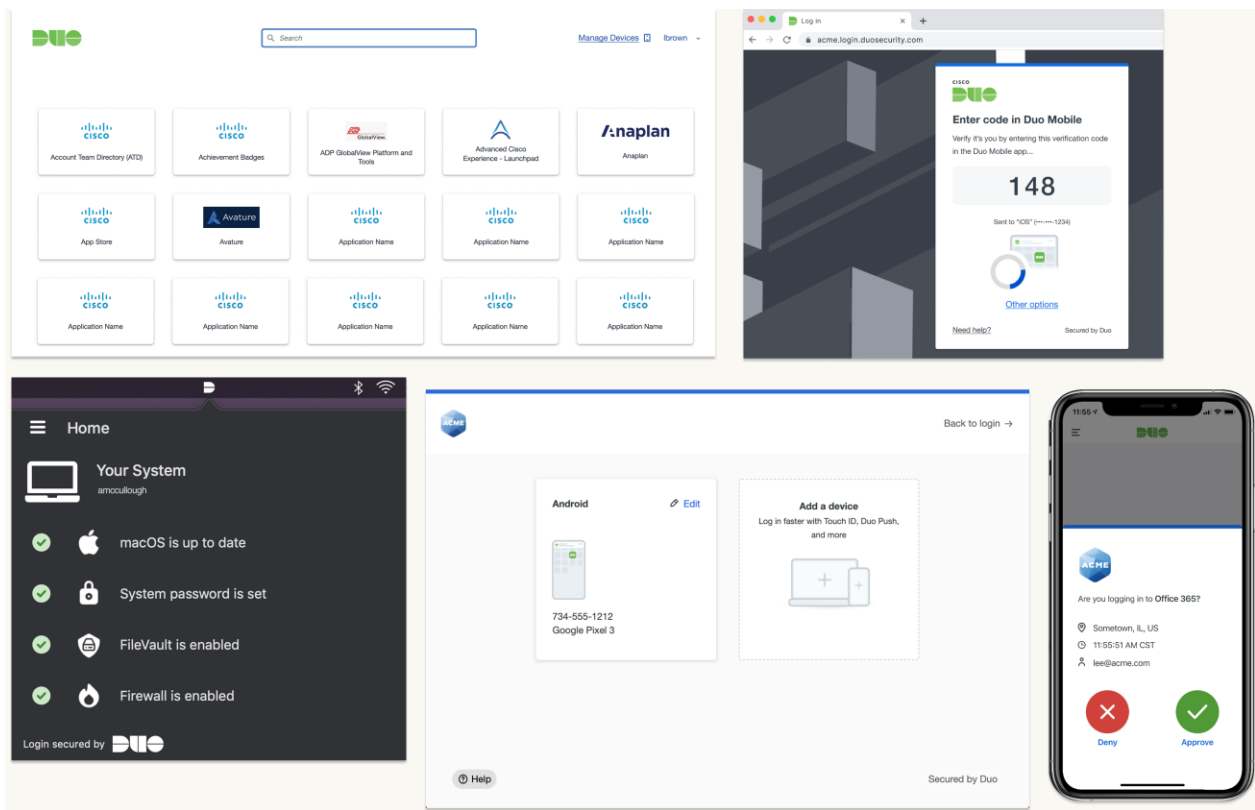


↑Building a vision for a streamlined self service experience

— OVERVIEW

Our self-service experience was fragmented

End users navigated multiple disconnected tools to manage their accounts and devices: a portal for enrolling devices, another for accessing applications, a mobile app for multi-factor authentication, and a separate desktop app for device health. No single place to do it all.

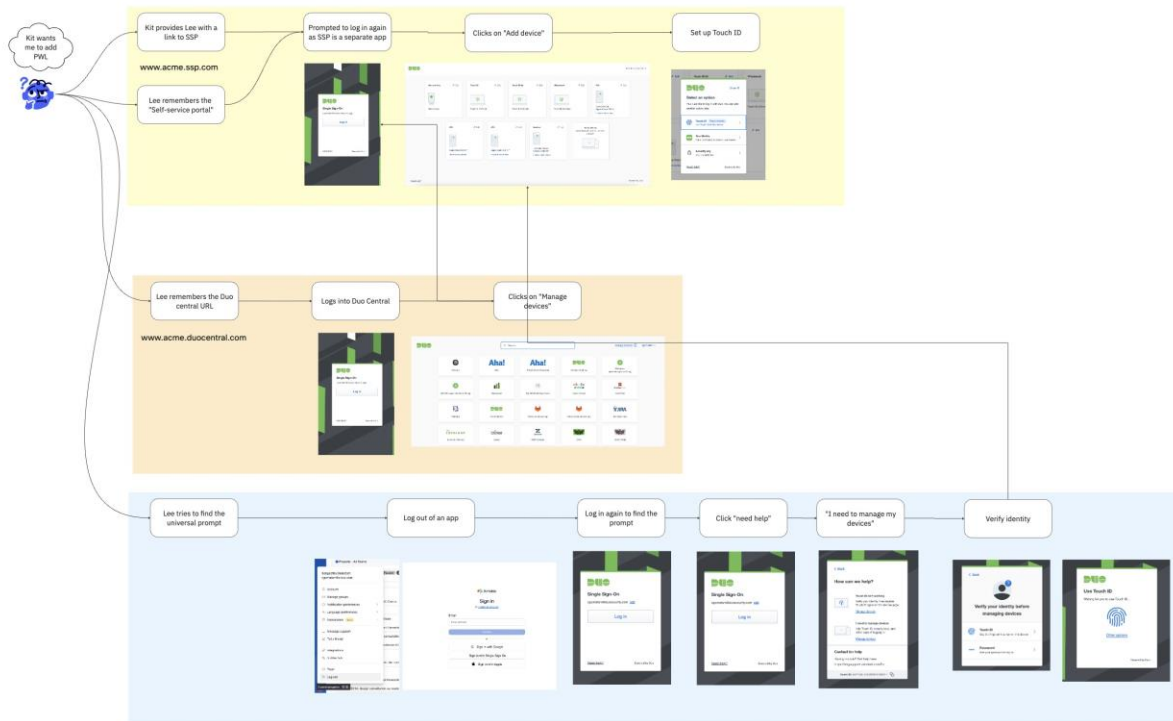


The fragmented Duo self-service landscape · five separate touchpoints with no unified home

..and scattered

The end user had too many touchpoints with no clear way to find them or understand their purpose.

The Duo prompt often served as a wayfinder to self-service tools, but as authentication became more frictionless, users encountered it less frequently and lost a reliable path back to these experiences. We hypothesized that this fragmentation discouraged users from self-triaging issues.



User journey map · navigating disconnected self-service touchpoints

— PROBLEM

How big is the problem, and what is the solution?

— SOLUTION

Conduct research to understand current self-service needs

- Interviewed 6 end users to understand the problems they ran into and assess their interest in self-triaging issues.
- Interviewed 6 IT admins and support specialists to understand pain points in managing these issues and explore how a self-service-first approach fits into their identity management strategy.

— FINDINGS

End users want to solve their own issues

I can accomplish it quicker. Often times I feel like when I call IT, there's some type of disconnect along the way that makes the process take longer

— End user at an ecommerce company

I'm someone that likes to figure things out on my own. I want to be as independent as possible.. that's where my frustration stems from.

— End user at a banking company

Increase in support burden and costs

- Average cost for a single password reset is \$70
- Costs increase for larger organizations using multiple AIM tools. IT admins prefer to empower end users to self-triage issues and reduce tool fragmentation.

The volume for password reset requests can reach up to ~15k per day during back to school season

Scale back and look at the big picture

As Cisco moves towards adding more security products to the suite, we'll have a further fragmented experience. Rather than waiting for this to become a problem, we need to lay the groundwork for a unified experience now.

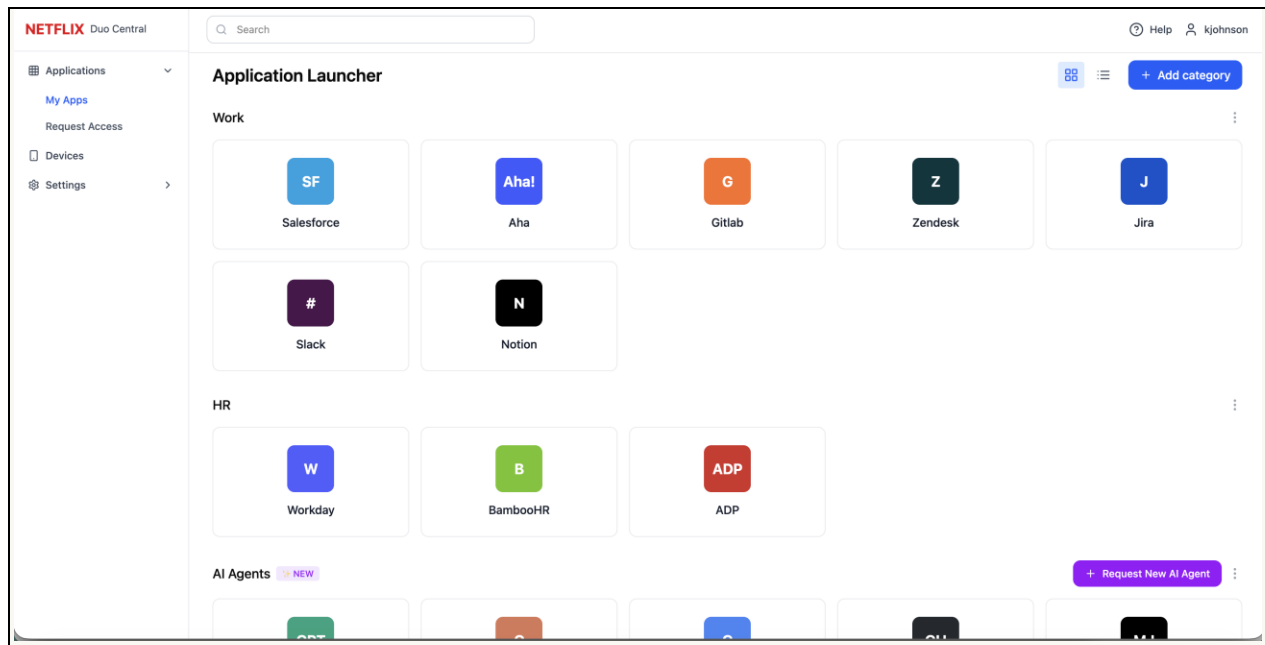
With new self-service capabilities emerging through Identity Governance and Administration, it became clear that these experiences needed a centralized home.

The ideal portal

- Secure: accessible only to verified end users
- Single source of truth
- Easy to find: set as browser's default
- Granular controls: IT admin manages exactly what actions end user can take
- Custom branding: so end users recognize and trust the portal

A future vision to work towards

- Lay ground work
- A place for new features



A vision for a streamlined self service portal. [Try the prototype →](#)

— PROBLEM

Building the ideal system was overwhelming

— SOLUTION

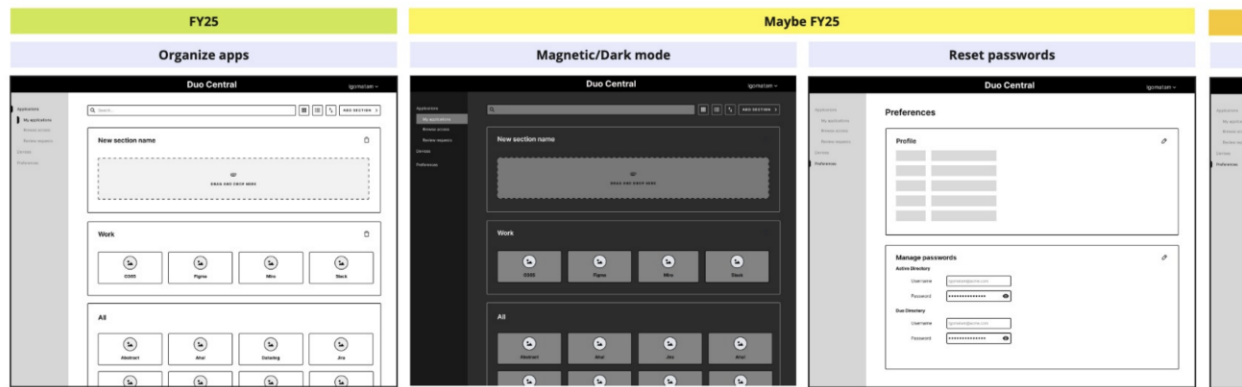
Push for a creating a foundation

- Start with one team, and a foundational project
- We identified the ideal place for a centralized experience
- We start by placing the foundation for future growth

— PUSHING FOR A FOUNDATION

Quick sketches to identify barriers

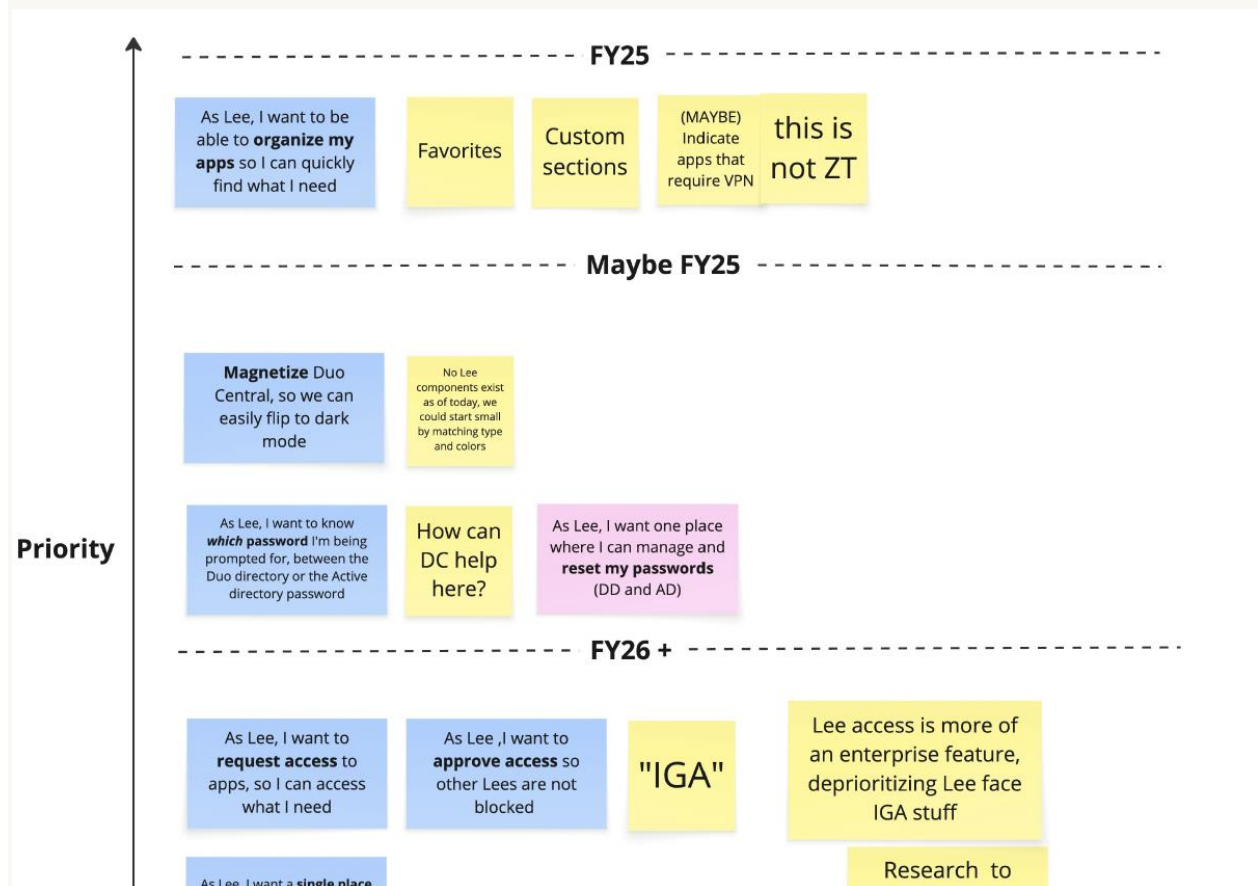
I broke down our user stories by features, so we could concerns and gauge interest from the PMs. I then ordered them by Fiscal year to help plan the roadmap



Quick sketches · user stories broken down by feature and fiscal year

Prioritizing features with PMs

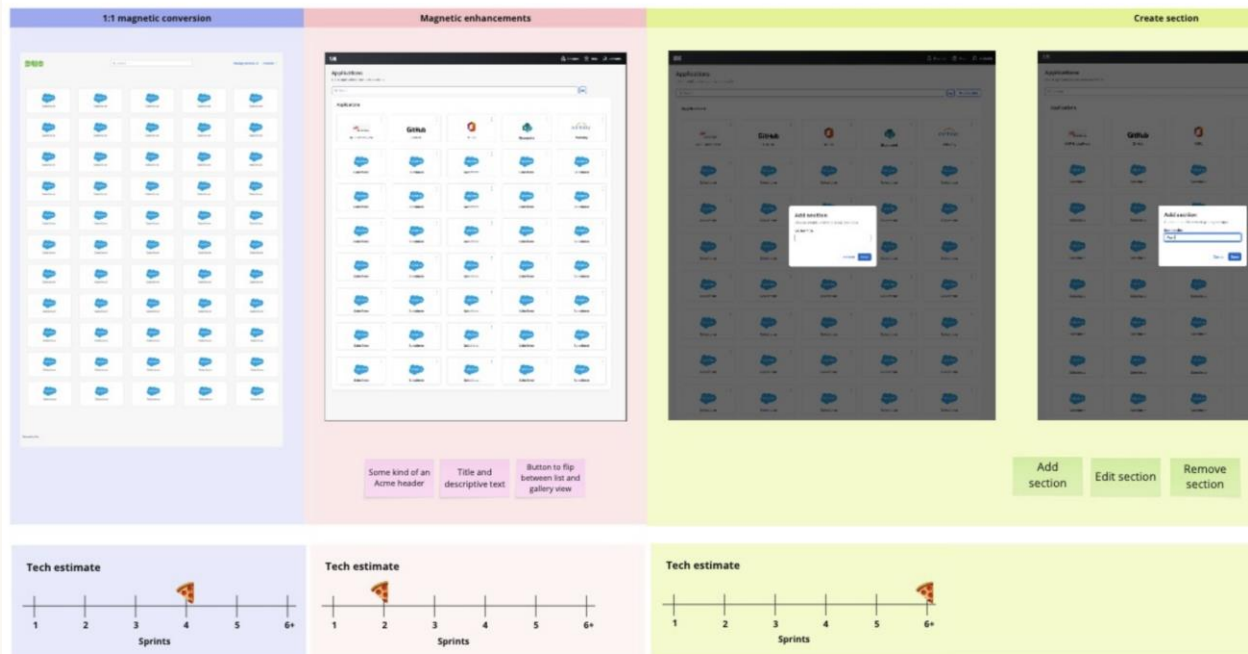
Based on feature discussions with product managers, I ran a prioritization exercise that surfaced early barriers and quick wins, helping the team converge on a clearer MVP direction.



Prioritization exercise · surfacing barriers and quick wins with PMs

Technical lift estimations

We didn't have clarity on the level of effort required, which made it difficult to set expectations or commitments. I translated early concepts into mid-fidelity flows and introduced a lightweight estimation scale. This gave engineers a faster way to evaluate complexity and align on relative effort.



Technical lift estimations · mid-fidelity flows mapped to engineering complexity

Bringing it together

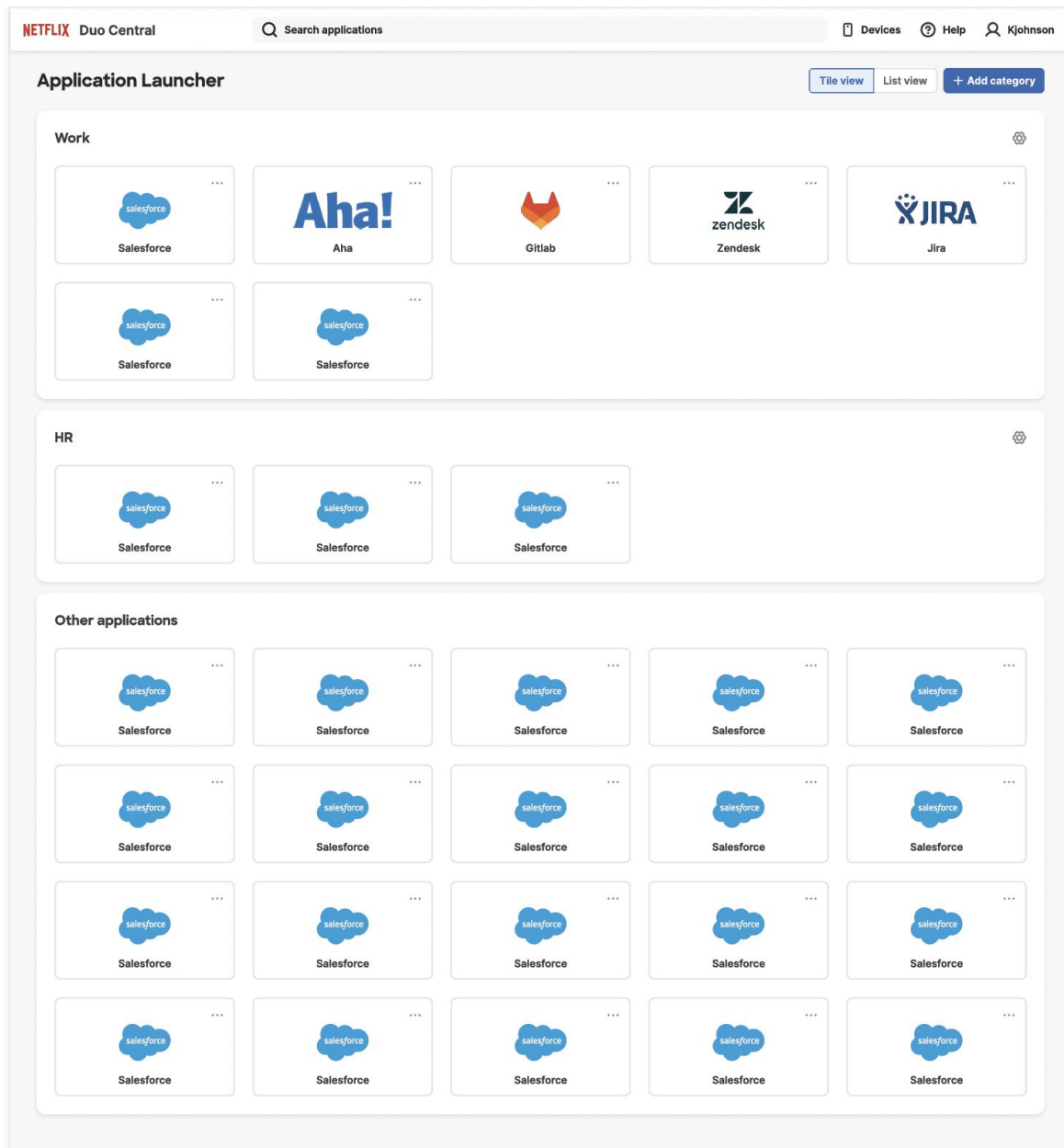
We combined product prioritization with technical effort estimates to define a focused and feasible MVP plan.

Feature	Effort in sprints	MVP		
1:1 magnetic conversion Sangeetha Mandayam Go...	4	Keep	Keep, but reduce scope 	Punt
Magnetic enhancements: Header, Page title & description, list vs icon view button Sangeetha Mandayam Go...	2	 Keep	Keep, but reduce scope	Punt
Create, edit, delete sections Sangeetha Mandayam Go...	6+	Keep 	Keep, but reduce scope	Punt
Move app to section Sangeetha Mandayam Go...	2			
Bulk move apps Sangeetha Mandayam Go...	4	Keep	Keep, but reduce scope	 Punt
Dark mode Sangeetha Mandayam Go...	3	Keep	Keep, but reduce scope 	Punt 

MVP plan · product priorities mapped against technical effort

Final designs

We laid the foundation for a single source of truth for self-service experiences. This included migrating to a standardized design system, introducing the ability to create and organize categories, and ensuring full responsiveness across devices. The feature is now in Beta.



Final designs · unified self-service portal in Beta

— PROBLEM

Building the ideal system was overwhelming

— PASSWORD RESET

Password reset crucial for IdP adoption

As Duo expanded into the identity space with password support, end users were unable to reset passwords on their own. Instead, password recovery required a manual troubleshooting process where IT admins generated temporary

passwords, shared them with users, and guided them through resetting credentials. This added operational overhead and made some IT admins hesitant to adopt the Duo IdP solution.

The image displays three sequential screenshots of a password reset interface for 'Acme'.

- First Screenshot: 'How can we help?'** This screen features a 'Back' link at the top left. It contains two main sections: 'I want to change my password' with instructions to log in and verify identity, and 'I forgot my password' with instructions to verify identity and follow steps to reset. Both sections include a 'Change my password' or 'Reset my password' link. At the bottom, there is a 'Contact for help' section with contact information and an 'Event ID' at the very bottom.
- Second Screenshot: 'Use Touch ID'** This screen prompts the user to 'Verify your identity using this device...' and features a large fingerprint icon. It includes 'Need help?' and 'Secured by Duo' links at the bottom.
- Third Screenshot: 'Reset your password'** This screen asks the user to 'Enter a new password that meets the following criteria:'. It lists three criteria: 'Must be least 12 characters', 'Passwords must match', and 'Must include at least one uppercase, lowercase letter, number (0-9), and symbol (!@#\$%^&*')'. It includes input fields for 'New password' and 'Confirm new password', a 'Show password' checkbox, and a 'Submit' button. It also has 'Need help?' and 'Secured by Duo' links at the bottom.

Password reset · manual recovery flow requiring IT admin involvement

— PASSWORD RESET

Deciphering the IT admin configuration

- We built a lightweight AI prototype to quickly validate the concept and get it in front of users.
- Through early testing with users, we aimed to understand what IT admins needed in order to feel confident enabling password reset, and to surface key gaps in the experience and requirements.

Self service policies

Enrollment policy Self service portal Self service password reset

Self service password reset

Use these configurations to enable your users to reset their Duo Directory passwords via the universal prompt.

Endpoint Verification

Checks for endpoints whose identity can be verified by Duo Desktop, or a browser cookie from an authentication within the last 30 days.

- ☒ **Required when not phishing-resistant**
Endpoint verification is always required for authentications that are not phishing-resistant. Not required when using a phishing-resistant method or identity verification.
- ☐ **Always required**
Endpoint verification is always required, no matter what authentication method is used for the password reset.

Authentication Methods

Define the authentication methods allowed for users to reset their passwords.

- ☒ Platform Authenticator Phishing-resistant
- ☒ Roaming Authenticator Phishing-resistant
- ☒ Duo Push with Proximity Verification Phishing-resistant
- ☐ Identity Verification
- ☐ Verified Duo Push
- ☐ Hardware Token
- ☐ Duo Mobile Passcode
- ☐ SMS Passcode
- ☐ Phone Call

Select groups

Define which users have access to self service password reset.

- ☐ Enable for all
- ☒ Enable for permitted groups

Power users × Admins × Add groups...

- ☐ Disable for all

Save

AI prototype · lightweight concept used for early IT admin validation

— FINDINGS

Users understood familiar patterns

- Authentication methods section was clear as it mirrored our earlier patterns
- Users were successfully able to configure and enable password reset

Authentication Methods

Define the authentication methods allowed for users to reset their passwords.

- ☒ Platform Authenticator Phishing-resistant
- ☒ Roaming Authenticator Phishing-resistant
- ☒ Duo Push with Proximity Verification Phishing-resistant
- ☐ Identity Verification
- ☐ Verified Duo Push
- ☐ Hardware Token
- ☐ Duo Mobile Passcode
- ☐ SMS Passcode
- ☐ Phone Call



Authentication methods · users successfully configured using familiar patterns

— FINDINGS

"Endpoint verification" was confusing

Almost all users said they didn't understand what this section meant. Internal terms like "endpoint" and "Duo Desktop" were confusing and created cognitive overload. While the goal was to reassure admins that additional protections were in place for less secure authentication methods, that message did not come through.

A device is a device is a device

Endpoint Verification

Checks for endpoints whose identity can be verified by Duo Desktop, or a browser cookie from an authentication within the last 30 days.

- ☒ **Required when not phishing-resistant**
Endpoint verification is always required for authentications that are not phishing-resistant. Not required when using a phishing-resistant method or identity verification.
- ☐ **Always required**
Endpoint verification is always required, no matter what authentication method is used for the password reset.

Before

Endpoint verification · internal jargon causing confusion during testing

— SOLUTION

Remove granularity that doesn't bring value

We decided to remove the "Endpoint" option from the user-facing experience, as it was causing more confusion than adding value. Instead we chose a Duo recommended default setting.

We also decided to use simple language that communicated outcomes for the end user rather than using technical jargon.

Other methods

i Users can reset their password using the following methods only if their device is registered with Duo Desktop or if they have logged into the device within the past 30 days. [Learn more](#) 

☒ **Verified Duo Push**

Requires users to verify every Duo Push with a code or Bluetooth.

☐ **Identity Verification**

Government-issued ID and face match

☐ **Duo Mobile Passcode**

One-time passcodes generated in Duo Mobile.

☐ **SMS Passcode**

Time-based one-time passcodes (TOTP) sent via SMS text message.

After

Simplified endpoint · outcome-focused language with Duo recommended defaults

— FINDING

Request for flexibility

In our early designs, we allowed admins to select a set of authentication methods and apply them broadly to user groups. However, research revealed that IT admins needed more granular control over these configurations. They wanted the ability to assign different authentication methods to different groups, define rules, and layer additional Duo features.

I want my contractors to be able to reset with a push, but my power users to use phishing resistant methods like biometrics

— IT admin

I want to tack on other security options like trusted devices

— IT admin

Authentication Methods

Define the authentication methods allowed for users to reset their passwords.

- ☒ Platform Authenticator Phishing-resistant
- ☒ Roaming Authenticator Phishing-resistant
- ☒ Duo Push with Proximity Verification Phishing-resistant
- ☐ Identity Verification
- ☐ Verified Duo Push
- ☐ Hardware Token
- ☐ Duo Mobile Passcode
- ☐ SMS Passcode
- ☐ Phone Call

Select groups

Define which users have access to self service password reset.

- ☐ Enable for all
- ☒ Enable for permitted groups

Power users × Admins × Add groups...

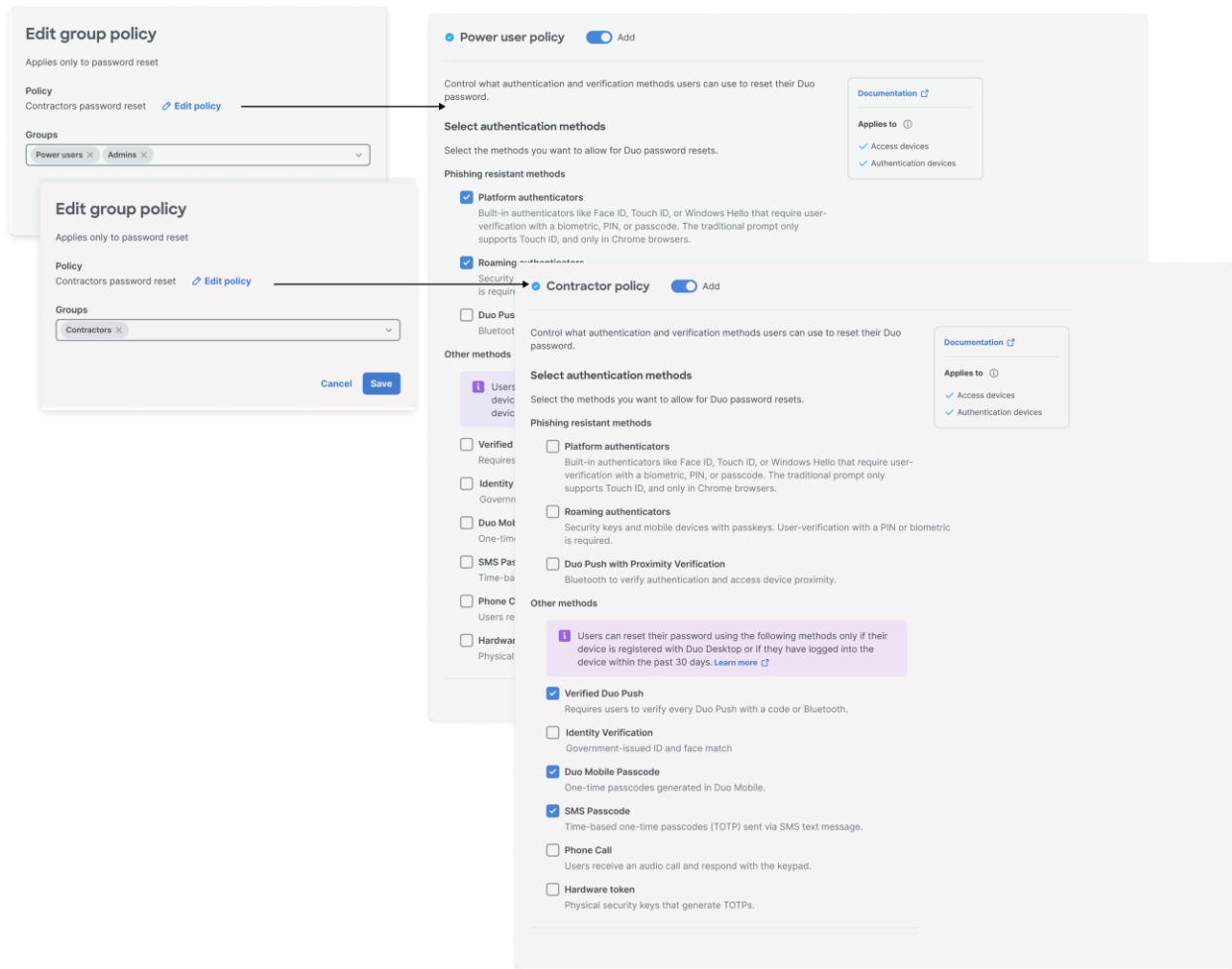
Before

Only one configuration for all the groups

— SOLUTION

Enable granularity where Admins need control

This required a complete redesign and introduced significant complexity. We needed to map different policies across multiple user groups. We were confident this tradeoff would be worthwhile, as it enables the flexibility needed for a wide range of IT admin scenarios.



After

Multi-group policy · granular authentication method control per user group

— SOLUTION

Tying it with the future vision

With the goal of eventual unification in mind, we moved the device adding and password settings under a single "self service policy" page.

This feature is currently being implemented

← Policies

Self-service policies

Duo provides self-service options that allow users to manage their authenticators and reset forgotten passwords.

Self-service portal

Self-service password reset

General

Enabling this feature allows users to reset their own password from the "Need Help?" link on the universal prompt. This is available during web login for any SSO application where Duo is configured as the authentication source.

User access

- ☐ Disable for all users
- ☐ Enable only for permitted groups
- ☒ Enable for all active users

Policies

These policies control how Lee verifies their identity while resetting their password

Group password reset policy

3 policies | 4 groups

Add group policy

Applies to specific groups of users who can reset their Duo password.

Default password reset policy

1 policy | All users

Edit default policy

Applies to all users who can reset their Duo password

Some of the default policy rules below are overridden by group policies.

Enabled rules	Details
Password reset methods	Deny - Duo Push with Proximity Verification, Verified Duo Push, Duo Mobile Passcode, SMS Passcode, Phone Call, Hardware token Allow - Platform authenticators, Roaming authenticators
User Location	Require 2FA: Aland Islands. All other countries: No action.

Future vision · device and password settings unified under self-service policy ← All workNEXT CASE STUDY

User provisioning →

Let's build
something together.

sgomatam.design@gmail.com →

[LinkedIn](#)

[Resume \(PDF\)](#)

© 2026 Sangeetha
Gomatam

